

The Advantages of Using WSL for Developing Linux Applications on Windows Systems

It is common to have cross-platform development of applications, since most developers do not have multiple machines. Today, it is quite simple to install a Linux development environment in a machine that has a Windows OS, thanks to the Windows Subsystem for Linux (WSL) feature offered by Microsoft.

Many Linux application developers have Windows OS machines and use remote Linux servers for work by connecting through SSH (like installing PuTTY software on Windows). These Linux servers/machines are generally shared among multiple developers for their development work. However, very often developers want their own machine instance and that is when a virtual machine (VM) is used.

On Windows OS based systems, there are VM solutions like VirtualBox or VMware, through which you can install any Linux distro (or any operating system for that matter) you like from an installer ISO. But many developers do not like this due to the performance (it's very slow and heavy for the overall host system), compatibility issues, lack of tools and support.

Windows Subsystem for Linux (WSL)

Remote host connections or virtual machines were the only ways to develop Linux applications on Windows

machines until Microsoft came up with WSL (Windows Subsystem for Linux) in 2016. WSL allows you to run Linux distributions on 64-bit Windows 10 (from version 1607) based systems. It only supported the Ubuntu Linux distribution initially, but now supports many other Linux distributions.

